he would be questioned in the court of history. ‘I may even be asked by my Maker why I used it but I shall defend myself vigorously and shall say – “Why did you release this knowledge to us when mankind was raging in furious battles?”’.[20]

During the Cold War the nuclear relationship between the superpowers came to be characterised as Mutual Assured Destruction (MAD). To those who sought to proselytise nuclear deterrence, the potential to prevent conventional aggression also offered the prospect of a strategy to end all wars. So how might nuclear war have begun at the height of the Cold War? The question unsurprisingly exercised strategists, political leaders, scholars, novelists, and filmmakers (not to mention Herman Kahn’s bank manager). In *On the Beach* war begins with an Albanian nuclear attack on Naples; Tel Aviv is then destroyed by a nuclear bomb; Egypt attacks London and Washington with Soviet-supplied long-range nuclear bombers; the US mistakenly believes that Moscow is responsible and attacks the USSR. The ‘NATO-Russia’ war then prompts the ‘Russia-China’ war, fought mainly with thermonuclear weapons containing cobalt. It is this that proves lethal to humanity.

All attempts to reimagine the past – be it through novels, films, war-games, or counterfactual histories – may seem implausible. In 1957 Albania, Egypt and China were not nuclear weapons states, and the Soviet Union did not provide its allies with thermonuclear weapons or long-range bombers. Quite why the Albanians wanted to destroy Naples, who destroyed Tel Aviv, and whether Soviet and Chinese nuclear war plans were tenable, are unclear from the novel. Suffice to say that Nevil Shute would have been wasting his time trying to get a thousand dollars out of Herman Kahn.

In *Dr Strangelove* nuclear war is started by a base commander who sends his nuclear bombers to attack the Soviet Union. Knowing that Moscow will retaliate, his aim is to coerce Washington into launching an all-out attack on the USSR to pre-empt their retaliation against the US. However, Moscow has secretly developed a Doomsday Machine. If any nuclear weapons explode on Soviet territory this will automatically trigger detonation of multiple thermonuclear weapons. These will create ‘a doomsday shroud’